oversee the programme to check if the coaches were being as diligent as they should.

I have very fond memories of the summer camps, particularly of the enthusiastic youngsters who never complained or tried to shirk their duties. I also remember with gratitude the help I received from Kashmir's chief minister, Farooq Abdullah, and his father, Sheikh Abdullah, who welcomed me to Srinagar and provided me with all facilities while we were there, and General Gurbaksh Singh, who kindly allowed me to hold a camp in Shimla's Annadale grounds, said to be the highest cricket ground in the world at that time. None of this would have been possible if I had been an unknown sports official. They knew and respected me, and above all, believed in what I was doing and never hesitated to extend every support they could to the cause.

Another policy I initiated in the early 1970s was to make the games period compulsory in every school in Punjab. I had learnt, to my horror, that since this period came at the end of the school day, it was the easiest one to bunk. I sent urgent appeals to all principals and physical training instructors throughout the state, telling them emphatically that it was their responsibility to ensure that all students attend this period, if they wanted their schools' sports standards to improve. The purpose of the period was to teach children to play games, to train them, to tell them what the rules were, but if there were no attendees, the entire exercise would become a farce. I emphasized that it was up to the principals or instructors to set examples, and if they were sincere, committed, and above all, strict, the students would be equally dedicated.

Throughout my tenure, the message I repeatedly sent to all institutions and associations was that if we wanted to improve the quality of sports, not only in Punjab but also throughout India, we should all unite and work towards a common goal. But to achieve that goal, each of us should be sincere and dedicated, whether it was the athlete, the coach or the association. Halfhearted measures will not work. I travelled extensively across Punjab to spread my message. Wherever I went, people would come up to me, saying that my son is a good runner, or is keen on football, can you give him a chance? I would then test them and if they were truly talented, I would place them in the relevant sports wing. What drove me was my deep desire to pass on what I knew to young children. For that purpose, I have never rested in my mission.